

Better Diets and Nutrition Science Program

Inception Report

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Acronyms and Abbreviations

AABS	Asia-Africa BlueTech Superhighway project
ANH Academy	Agriculture, Nutrition, and Health Academy
AoW	Area of Work
ESA	East and Southern Africa
F&V	fruit and vegetables
FBDG	food-based dietary guidelines
GAP	Good Agricultural Practices
GI	glycemic index
HLO	high-level output
HLPE	High-Level Panel of Experts on Food Security and Nutrition
IA	Impact Area
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
LMIC	low- and middle-income country
M&E	monitoring and evaluation
MDD	minimum dietary diversity
MELIA	monitoring, evaluation, learning, and impact assessment
MSME	micro, small and medium enterprise
N4G	Nutrition for Growth Summit
NAP-FST	national action plans for food systems transformation
NGO	non-governmental organization
PNR	perishable nutrient-rich
PORB	Plan of Results and Budget
PRMS	Performance and Results Management System
RCT	randomized controlled trial
SA	South Asia
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SEA	Southeast Asia
ToC	theory of change
ToT	training of trainers
UN	United Nations
UNFSS	United Nations Food Systems Summit
UPF	ultra-processed food
WCA	West and Central Africa
WUR	Wageningen University and Research
WorldVeg	World Vegetable Center

Executive summary

Within the new CGIAR Portfolio, Better Diets and Nutrition challenges traditional ways of thinking about how to remake food systems to improve diets. Rather than focusing on solutions related to production, technology, and efficiency alone, this Program views consumers as the strategic entry point for systemic change. Food systems transformation is viewed as an opportunity to improve diets and nutrition by changing the deeper, system-wide issues that prevent people from being able to eat in ways that are both good for their health and the planet.

The Program tackles five constraints to sustainable healthy diets — accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency. Through rigorous, transdisciplinary research and strategic partnerships, it co-generates actionable evidence and builds joint capacities to scale solutions that are grounded in equity, inclusivity, and co-creation.

This inception phase report summarizes the progress made during the program's first six months, with a focus on key deliverables, strategic realignments, and responses to feedback from the CGIAR Independent Science for Development Council, the CGIAR System Council, the Integrated Partnership Board, and other key stakeholders. Importantly, this report demonstrates how the feedback has been incorporated into the refined programmatic framework, research agenda, and operational structure.

The revised Theory of Change (ToC) now outlines two synergistic pathways: *policy interventions* to create enabling environments and *innovations* that improve affordability, accessibility, availability, desirability, and agency for healthier food choices. The ToC has incorporated new assumptions, clarified actor roles, and explained how capacity sharing has an important role in accelerating change. The revised ToC clarifies consumer agency, their motivations, and the structural barriers (e.g., affordability, desirability) they face in making choices.

The Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA) plan describes how the Program will monitor progress, test core assumptions, assess pathway effectiveness, and improve adaptive learning through 2030. The goal is for people to consume sustainable healthy diets that are accessible, affordable, available, and desirable and have agency to make their own choices. Progress towards this goal will be measured by two indicators, the percentage of women of reproductive age achieving minimum dietary diversity and the percentage of the population who can afford a healthy diet.

The 2025 Plan of Results and Budget (PORB) is based on a total budget of US\$33.8 million from pooled funding and Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects. Budget allocations were informed by stakeholder consultations and the comparative advantage and prioritization exercises. Strategic allocations support integration, capacity sharing, and collaboration with local and global partners to maximize delivery and learning. Pooled funding will be used for focused research and fieldwork in 15 countries: eight in Africa (Benin, Ethiopia, Ghana, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, Tanzania, Uganda); five in Asia (Bangladesh, India, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, and Viet Nam); and two in Latin America (Guatemala and Honduras). Lastly, the mapping of the Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects to this Program followed a thorough process to assess that their results will contribute to the Program's ToC.

1. Program overview

1.1 High-level vision

Globally, food systems are failing to deliver healthy diets for all in a sustainable and equitable way. Almost three billion people worldwide cannot afford healthy diets. Perishable nutrient-rich (PNR) foods are often unavailable, especially in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs) in Africa and Asia. Urbanization, changes in agri-food systems and the rise of cheap, highly processed, nutrient-poor foods are worsening diets. Climate change, conflict, and economic instability further undermine the provision of sustainable healthy diets to populations in LMICs through food systems, contributing to widespread malnutrition in all its forms – undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies, obesity, and diet-related non-communicable diseases - and rising health and economic costs.

The Better Diets and Nutrition Program aims to increase the consumption of sustainable healthy diets. Within the new CGIAR Portfolio, this Program challenges traditional ways of thinking about how to transform food systems to improve diets by viewing consumers as the strategic entry point for systemic change, rather than focusing on solutions related to production, technology, and efficiency alone. The Program uses a food systems approach rooted in the High-Level Panel of Experts on Food Security and Nutrition’s (HLPE) [food systems framework](#) and addresses five key constraints that shape the healthiness of diets, accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency, working across the entire food system from consumer to producer. Through research, engagement, and capacity sharing, the research builds evidence for system-wide solutions that overcome these constraints to support governance and drive investments to attain sustainable healthy diets and curb the current unhealthy and harmful megatrends damaging the health of people and the planet.

Over the next six years, the Program will make significant contributions to CGIAR’s 2030 targets in the Impact Area (IA) on Nutrition, Health, and Food Security (Nutrition), while contributing to broader efforts on climate, sustainability, livelihoods, and equity. These results will be achieved through partnerships within and beyond the agricultural sector, targeted interventions in national food system pathways, and by leveraging CGIAR’s expertise in diets, nutrition, and social science.

1.2 Achievements from 2022—2024

Better Diets and Nutrition builds on extensive diagnostic work completed over the past three years plus important global and regional engagements. The [2024 annual technical reports](#) summarize these accomplishments. Three examples are provided below.

Solutions that make nutritious foods more accessible and affordable

Lack of reasonably priced cold storage drives food loss and waste of PNR foods in LMICs, making them less affordable for consumers. In the Philippines, a CGIAR market assessment found a significant and growing gap between local supply and demand for fresh produce, driven in part by postharvest losses of 20 to 40%. Program partners are piloting [CoolBot](#), a simple air conditioner and insulated room to maintain storage temperatures of 10°C or lower, in an important production area supplying markets in Manila. Similarly, in northeastern Nigeria, Program partners have been piloting a similar technology, [ColdHubs](#), with tomato wholesalers at three horticultural markets and measuring the effects on vegetable supply and prices.

End-to-end approach to improve consumption of fruits and vegetables

Another major result from the previous Portfolio was the development of the “end-to-end approach” for fruit and vegetables (F&V), which entails the co-location of interconnected interventions from consumers to producers that combine demand generation for F&V, food

environment improvements, and supply-side support. It drives increased F&V intake by addressing barriers across the food system and is being tested in Benin, the Philippines, Sri Lanka and Tanzania. Two rigorous evaluations of the contextually relevant co-designed approach are underway in Sri Lanka and Tanzania. Early results are promising. Pilot interventions targeting the supply chain demonstrated improved production outcomes and increased income for producers. Notably, vegetables grown at the designated production hubs showed lower input use and reduced contamination levels compared to those from traditional supply chains, which indicates not only health benefits but also environmental and economic advantages. These efforts offer valuable insights into how integrated food system solutions, which are tailored and tested in real-world settings, can effectively address barriers to sustainable healthy diets.

Capacity to support implementation of national food systems transformation plans

One of the major outputs from the previous Portfolio was a training of trainers (ToT) program on food systems for sustainable healthy diets. The program was co-designed with national partners to build capacity among actors involved in implementing actions that are part of their country's food systems transformation agendas. By the end of 2024, more than 300 people had been trained, and the program was embedded within subnational implementation strategies in Viet Nam and was set to expand in Ethiopia pending the finalization of a national training manual. Working alongside government partners, the Program will institutionalize the ToT program as part of their national action plans for food systems transformation (NAP-FST) and compile case studies or briefs from Viet Nam and Ethiopia highlighting how the training is adapted, delivered, and embedded at subnational levels in 2025.

1.3 Description of intended research

Research in this Program's six Areas of Work (AoW) encompasses global-level analysis, covering a variety of food system typologies with different dietary challenges, as well as global trends. In 2025, pooled funding will be used for focused research and fieldwork in 15 countries: eight in Africa (Benin, Ethiopia, Ghana, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, Tanzania, Uganda); five in Asia (Bangladesh, India, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, and Viet Nam); and two in Latin America (Guatemala and Honduras). The research plans have not fundamentally changed from what was described in the approved proposal. Research is conducted in ways that build on CGIAR's strengths, including its convening capacity, and using a broad mix of quantitative and qualitative methods and co-creation approaches. Research will be jointly designed, implemented, analyzed, and disseminated with local research institutes to strengthen shared capacity and learning. This work is highly transdisciplinary, so the Program will continue to rely on integrated research teams with both technical and contextual expertise within and outside of CGIAR.

Consumers and Food Environments

AoW1 uses mixed-methods research to support government-led efforts to shift consumer behavior and food environments in support of sustainable healthy diets, while also advancing equity, income, food safety, and environmental goals. Generated evidence comes from policy analysis, political economy research, and consumer studies, including pilots and evaluations of solutions such as national food-based dietary guidelines (FBDG), food labeling, taxes, and vendor-focused strategies. AoW1's assessments of dietary intake, its drivers, and food environments help characterize consumption patterns and barriers to change. Scenario modelling and trade-off analyses inform multisector foresight dialogues. The primary entry point in each country is the NAP-FST. The team's close collaborations with government actors involve co-design of technical support, training, and monitoring systems that track transformation processes. This AoW promotes south-south learning, strengthens science-policy interfaces, and facilitates inclusive coalitions to help countries adaptively manage their national food system transitions. *Focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Ghana, Guatemala, Honduras, Kenya, Tanzania, and Viet Nam.*

Market Systems

AoW2 has three specific research angles aimed at improving market systems for sustainable nutritious foods that are part of a sustainable healthy diet food basket. First, it investigates innovative approaches to reward food quality, reduce food safety risks, lower transaction costs among value chain actors, and minimize food loss and waste. These improvements help increase the availability of sustainable nutritious foods but are insufficient alone to grow markets. Second, it focuses on innovations in finance markets, including insurance and blended finance, to understand which finance actors are willing to invest in new products and design tailored financial solutions that increase investment flows, expanding market availability and affordability. Third, this AoW studies broader macroeconomic issues shaping food availability, including regulations affecting ultra-processed foods (UPF) and the role of international trade in accessing healthier options. Throughout the process, the team uses innovative qualitative and quantitative data collection methods to enhance evidence quality. Research initiated in 2025 will align closely with the NAP-FST in AoW2's countries to ensure alignment with national priorities and maximize policy impact. *Focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Honduras, India, Kenya, Nigeria, and Uganda.*

End-to-End Approaches

Anchored in a whole-of-diet perspective, AoW3 starts with consumers and understanding their dietary patterns, gaps, excesses, and drivers. The team investigates context- and population-specific barriers—accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency—that limit intake of PNR foods or lead to their displacement by nutrient-poor options. AoW3 follows an end-to-end approach, the co-location of interconnected solutions from consumers to producers that combine demand generation for F&V, food environment improvements, and supply-side support. The approach prioritizes co-creation with a range of stakeholders, including community members, ensuring solutions are relevant and tailored to beneficiary needs. Specifically, this AoW focuses on increasing intake of F&V, aquatic foods, and terrestrial animal-source foods while reducing food loss and waste, improving affordability, minimizing environmental harm, supporting livelihoods, and for F&V only, promoting sustainable production and post-harvest practices. Research methods include dietary assessments, household surveys, food environment assessments, studies on food loss and food safety, processing and storage innovation trials, agronomic practices, pricing and demand analyses, willingness-to-pay experiments, impact evaluations, cost-benefit analyses, scenario modeling, and policy research. The evidence generated will be embedded in national processes to support scaling of inclusive, equitable end-to-end solutions. The team's collaboration with governments and platforms like food system alliances enables shared learning, technical support, and capacity sharing. *Focus in 2025: Benin, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, and Uganda.*

Biofortified and Health-Enhancing Staples

AoW4 aims to increase the consumption of biofortified crops, such as the orange-fleshed sweet potato, and health-enhancing crops such as low glycemic index (GI) rice, as part of a food basket supporting sustainable healthy diets. It builds on CGIAR's investments and innovations to improve the nutrient and health enhancing quality of commonly consumed staple crops. AoW4's research agenda, building on understanding consumption patterns and drivers of food choice, generates evidence to influence, develop, and upgrade value chains for biofortified and health-enhancing crops; promote their sustained adoption; and scale nutrient-dense varieties and products to promote consumption by diverse consumers. The aim is to make these improved varieties a market and consumer success. The team's research activities include building the evidence base for new biofortified and health-enhancing crops, developing and determining consumer acceptance of affordable, minimally processed food products using biofortified and health-enhancing crops as ingredients, and understanding and addressing constraints to the uptake of

biofortified and health-enhancing crops and products. Research approaches include efficacy and effectiveness of trials, product development, consumer, and market research, impact evaluations, descriptive studies, and policy analyses and engagement. *Focus in 2025: Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Guatemala, India, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, the Philippines, and Uganda.*

NB. This Program will not carry out production-related research, except for AoW3's work on F&V. For AoW3, supply side issues related to aquaculture and livestock science are important and fall under the domain of Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods with whom joint work is planned (**Section 8**); the [World Vegetable Center](#) (WorldVeg) provides expertise in vegetable production. For AoW4, crop and agronomic science fall under the mandate of Breeding for Tomorrow and Sustainable Farming.

Multisectoral Systems

In response to stakeholder feedback, AoW5 has been reframed to focus on understanding how complementary interventions in LMICs can enhance the positive impact of food system transformation on diets and nutrition. Key areas include social protection programs that improve household purchasing power and empower marginalized groups, as well as institutional catering (e.g., school meals, community kitchens). Nutrition education, behavior change communication, counseling, and gender-focused campaigns addressing roles and norms related to diets are also priorities. These complementary actions help ensure inclusive access and that improved food availability leads to nutritional benefits. The team's research methods include systematic reviews, meta-analyses, large-scale data analysis, and case studies. In the future, AoW5's activities may expand to include implementation research, impact evaluations, and cost-effectiveness studies supported by pooled funding. **Section 7** explains why AoW5's activities will start after 2025.

Transformative Leadership

AoW6 integrates insights from across the Program and CGIAR Portfolio to accelerate improvements in diets and nutrition. It consolidates evidence, tools, and lessons to inform policy, governance, and coordination at national, regional, and global levels. The work supports cross-country learning and strengthens food systems transformation capacities through strategic engagement and shared knowledge. AoW6 aims to build a cadre of local leaders committed to advancing sustainable healthy diets across diverse contexts. Research methods include evidence synthesis, policy reviews, and governance studies. Complementary activities include leadership development, capacity sharing, and promoting the use of tailored, diet-focused indicators to guide agriculture and food system sectors. By embedding research and learning in global networks, AoW6 ensures that CGIAR's work contributes to broad, systemic change for improved nutrition.

Value proposition

Better Diets and Nutrition delivers system-wide solutions to transform food systems for sustainable healthy diets. With consumers as the entry point, the Program tackles five constraints to sustainable healthy diets — accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency. Through rigorous, transdisciplinary research and strategic partnerships, it co-generates actionable evidence and builds joint capacities to scale solutions that are grounded in equity, inclusivity, and co-creation. Anchored in the CGIAR Portfolio, the Program accelerates impacts in nutrition, health, and food security while contributing to broader goals on climate, equity, and livelihoods and positions food systems as a critical lever to improve diets and planetary well-being.

2. Codesign and partnerships

During the design and inception phases

The proposal describes the mechanisms used to engage with partners and stakeholders during the design phase. The most significant result of those engagements was the addition of Biofortified and Health-Enhancing Staples (AoW4).

This Program has been guided by a unique and important iterative co-design process that was established in the previous Portfolio with implementers of the NAP-FST in Bangladesh, Ethiopia, and Viet Nam and multisectoral stakeholder groups in Tanzania, Sri Lanka, Benin and Philippines. The Program's Country Coordinators in these countries, alongside the CGIAR Country Convenors in some cases, facilitate continuous and active participation in country-owned processes. As a result, research priorities and implementation are co-identified and co-designed based on national priorities and maintain relevance as the implementation of the NAP-FST and other relevant policies and strategies evolves. In the inception phase, these known priorities have been incorporated into the outputs, outcomes, and assumptions in the revised ToC.

In the inception phase, writing team members engaged with their in-country partners as part of stocktaking workshops, stakeholder meetings, and policy symposia to discuss with close partners how the work would evolve under the new Program. Strong demand for capacity-sharing support on food system transformation toward sustainable healthy diets in Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, and Viet Nam was incorporated into the revised ToC. For example, members of AoW3 convened meetings in [the Philippines](#), [Sri Lanka](#), and [Tanzania](#) with a range of stakeholders (e.g., governments, nongovernmental organizations [NGOs], United Nations [UN] organizations, academia, farmer organizations and others with interests in F&V value chains). The meetings leveraging the multisectoral stakeholder groups that were created in the previous Portfolio in Sri Lanka and the Philippines and those involved in the Nutrition Sensitive Interventions Thematic Working Group of the National Multisectoral Nutrition Action Plan II, of which AoW3 was a member. National and subnational government actors, researchers, UN agencies, and NGOs involved in their national food systems transformation process met with members of AoW1 in [Bangladesh](#), [Ethiopia](#), and [Viet Nam](#). Partner engagement helped to align the 2025 activities to national needs.

A dedicated session on Better Diets and Nutrition at CGIAR Science Week was attended by more than 150 people. This led to the identification of potential partners, especially from the African continent for co-designing and co-developing consumer-oriented food system solutions that will contribute results to the ToC. The interactions also helped the team to clarify the integration of the Program's approach to increasing the affordability of healthy diets across all six AoWs. CGIAR Science Week demonstrated to the team that there is an urgent need to improve and align understanding of diets and nutrition within CGIAR, which AoW6 has incorporated in their ToC.

Another side event at CGIAR Science Week on how to accelerate the uptake of biofortified and health-enhancing crops in LMICs attracted more than 80 stakeholders (online and in person). The stakeholders reiterated their support for research on biofortified and health-enhancing staples with a focus on the food basket approach and emphasized the opportunity for strengthening collaborations and coordination. There is growing interest in biofortifying sustainable aquatic and animal foods—enhancing vitamin B12 in meat, omega-3s and minerals in fish, zinc in milk, and essential fatty acids in eggs. This evolving focus offers collaboration opportunities with Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods.

Several high-level dialogues and events in the inception phase provided further opportunities to engage with partners in ways that position sustainable healthy diets on the global or regional agendas and aligned the Program's research agenda with global and regional ambitions. For example, this Program influenced CGIAR to make a commitment for the Nutrition for Growth (N4G) Summit in Paris to provide much-needed evidence on what works to make sustainable healthy diets accessible, affordable, available, and desirable to people living in LMICs.

Looking ahead

In seven countries, the Program relies on its current Country Coordinators to foster national engagement, maintain trusted partnerships, and strengthen extensive networks. Research teams will regularly engage with in-country partners. As a Program, annual meetings will be planned with partners to discuss emerging research findings and relevance to policy priorities.

In addition, the Program will adopt multiple strategies to regularly convene research users, implementers, and close research collaborators to ensure our work remains relevant and responsive. Other mechanisms that will be used as part of implementation and adaptive management are listed below.

Annual scientific meetings

When funding allows, the Program will plan scientific meetings around other relevant conferences, like the [Agriculture, Nutrition, and Health Academy](#) (ANH Academy) Week, the Delivering for Nutrition conference, and Micronutrient Forum, to get inputs from a wider group of stakeholders beyond the in-country partners on research plans, solutions that could be evaluated, and to identify new, relevant partnerships as the Program progresses.

Communities of practice

Starting with the inputs gathered at CGIAR Science Week, the transdisciplinary community of practice for CGIAR stakeholders led by AoW4 will be an important co-design mechanism used by the Program as CGIAR breeding programs are a first order group of people affected by our work. The CGIAR task force on nutrition, health and food security, led by AoW6, will start activities in 2025 that will guide the new CGIAR Portfolio along pathways that lead to credible impacts on diets and nutrition.

Global and regional dialogues, coalitions, and policy processes

There are numerous opportunities for this Program to engage in high-level dialogues, coalitions, and regional policy processes, frequently at the request of partners. These relate to the UN Food Systems Summit (UNFSS) process, which started in 2021, and the [Coalition of Action on Healthy Diets from Sustainable Food Systems for Children and All](#), in particular; the [3rd International Agrobiodiversity Congress](#); and the next 10-year Comprehensive Africa Agriculture Development Program. The Program's engagement provides opportunities to disseminate and discuss evidence from research to influence policy processes and decisions, to multiply this to countries other than our 15 countries, and to adjust and adapt research to new and cross-cutting priorities including climate and biodiversity.

Funder engagement

Regularly talking with funders to hear their views will be a priority. The Leadership Team will organize an annual call for all funders and quarterly calls with the group of funders who are keen to discuss our work in more detail. The Leadership Team expects to work closely with bilateral fundraising efforts of CGIAR Centers to bring additional bilateral resources to the Portfolio.

3. Theory of change and MELIA

3.1 *Summary of changes to the theory of change*

Better Diets and Nutrition views food systems transformation as an opportunity to promote the consumption of sustainable healthy diets by working together with partners to address system-wide issues that are harming people and the planet. The Program focuses on five interlinked constraints to sustainable healthy diets, accessibility, affordability, availability, desirability, and agency.

This Program will contribute significantly to the CGIAR IA on Nutrition. By 2030, we expect consumers to consume sustainable healthy diets that are accessible, affordable, available, and desirable and have agency to make their own choices. Progress towards this goal will be measured by two indicators, the percentage of women of reproductive age achieving minimum dietary diversity (MDD) and the percentage of the population who can afford a healthy diet. The MDD was also recently adopted as a [new indicator](#) for Sustainable Development Goal 2 (SDG) on Zero Hunger, which links this Program even better to the SDGs. We aim to achieve a 10% increase on average for both indicators by 2030 across six selected countries (Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Honduras, Philippines, Tanzania and Viet Nam).

The revised ToC articulates a more coherent and operational model of change, structured around two synergistic pathways. The *policy pathway* emphasizes government actions (e.g., regulations, taxes, trade policies, subsidies, FBDG) that create conditions that enable food system actors, from consumers to producers, to adopt new practices that overcome the barriers to sustainable healthy diets. The *innovation pathway* emphasizes testing technologies or practices (“solutions”) that increase productivity and efficiency along different points of the value chain for sustainable nutritious foods and address consumer constraints (convenience, price, desirability) to overcome the barriers to sustainable healthy diets. Solutions encompass those developed within and outside of CGIAR. Together, these pathways function as a system-wide mechanism to alter both the supply and demand dynamics of food systems.

Capacity sharing, in the language of the CGIAR Capacity Sharing Accelerator, “accelerates the transfer, acquisition, sharing, and retention of essential capacities,” and will therefore accelerate our progress along both pathways.

Within the ToC, there are three approaches by which change is expected to occur:

1. Consumer-oriented policy strategies
2. Market-oriented solutions
3. Holistic, integrated actions along the entire value chain (“end-to-end”) to promote perishable, nutrient-rich foods and biofortified and health-enhancing staples.

The revised ToC emphasizes that actors across the food system are not passive recipients of change. It clearly articulates their motivations, roles, and the incentives that trigger behavior change, particularly for consumers, whose agency is now explicitly addressed (see ISDC Review, 2024). Government actors are expected to adopt policy solutions based on evidence and ability/capacity to do so; private actors engage when incentives align; and consumers are supported to exert agency in their food choices. Entry points are tailored across 15 countries based on context, sequencing, and complementarity with bilateral efforts (ISDC Review 2024).

A regional and global feedback mechanism, grounded in AoW6, supports evidence synthesis and policy engagement to scale country-level learning across the CGIAR Portfolio. This mechanism now more clearly incorporates internal CGIAR learning loops and promotes coherence across the CGIAR Portfolio, driving CGIAR results on the IA on Nutrition and addressing prior ambiguity about AoW6's role in scaling (ISDC Review Nov 2024).

MELIA efforts, while retaining a focus on adaptive learning, have been sharpened to test core assumptions around causal links and pathway effectiveness (ISDC Review Nov 2024). This includes assessing how many entry points must operate together to achieve dietary change and identifying when phased or partial implementation is sufficient. This targeted learning process ensures that vague or unstated assumptions from the original ToC are now systematically investigated through structured inquiry. Importantly, the ToC acknowledges that achieving end outcomes depends on preconditions—such as robust food control mechanisms that ensure the quality and safety of food, functioning infrastructure, and local institutional capacity—that lie beyond the Program's direct scope but must be recognized and leveraged (ISDC Review Nov 2024).

Finally, the revised ToC strengthens systems framing by integrating upstream and downstream actors, science and policy levers, and national and global dynamics. It positions the Program not as an isolated set of interventions, but as an embedded component of a broader system of change, contributing to the CGIAR Portfolio's wider impact goals in coordination with other Programs and Accelerators (ISDC Review Nov 2024).

Table 3.1 Comparative Overview of the ToC: Proposal vs. Inception Phase Version

Dimension	Proposal ToC	Revised ToC (Inception Phase)
2030 Outcome	Aimed to improve diets and nutrition, but without specific measurement framing	Anchored in IA on Nutrition; measurable indicators (MDD-W and affordability of healthy diet) defined
Pathways of Change	Framed around broad levers (innovation, capacity development, policy)	Defined two core pathways: enabling environment and system actor engagement and harmonized capacity sharing as accelerator for both
Actor roles & motivations	Focused more on outputs; consumer roles were underdeveloped and system actors appeared passive	Clearly articulated roles and motivations of key actors, including consumers (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
Geographic specificity	Countries were listed but not clearly linked to strategy	Country list retained; clearer explanation of how entry points vary and align with context (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
Assumptions	Vague or implicit	Key assumptions surfaced and embedded in MELIA design for testing (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
Feedback mechanism (AoW6)	Present, but link to learning loops and scaling was unclear	Emphasized as a system-level connector of national learning towards regional and global influence (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
Climate & resilience	Downplayed in original ToC	Integrated into next-level outcomes (e.g., resilience to shocks) (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
Systems framing	Implied but not explicit	Framed explicitly as systemic and non-linear, linking actor incentives and multiple levers (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
MELIA logic	Limited articulation; most focus remained at activity level.	Clear behavioral outcomes mapped by system actor, tied to contributions from

Dimension	Proposal ToC	Revised ToC (Inception Phase)
		AoWs and external conditions. (ISDC Review Nov 2024)
Program lineage & foundations	Mentioned abstractly; little visibility on how next-level change might emerge.	Inclusive food system resilience, institutionalized strategies, private sector alignment, and consumer uptake as legacy impacts. (ISDC Review Nov 2024)

The revised ToC narrative is available in the MELIA plan (link available in **Section 3.2**). In addition there is a digital diagram available [here](#).

3.2 *Summary of the Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA) Plan*

The MELIA Plan aligns with CGIAR’s 2025–2030 Results Framework and supports tracking high-level outputs (HLOs) and outcomes through a decentralized monitoring system with strong central coordination. This approach enables both accountability and adaptive learning across six AoWs. The Program relies on CGIAR’s online Performance and Results Management System (PRMS). HLOs are measured by reported results, such as innovations in development, capacity sharing activities, and knowledge products, while outcomes assess behavioral and systemic changes (primarily policy changes and use of innovations). Monitoring responsibilities are distributed across six AoWs, with AoW Leads overseeing HLO documentation. A 50% MELIA Focal Point in the Program Management Unit leads outcome-level tracking and assumption validation, while scientists support data collection, analysis, reporting and dissemination. Monitoring outputs feed directly into the PRMS for continuous progress tracking and reporting.

Six evaluations are planned to assess strategic coherence, actor engagement, organizational structure, and evidence use. Key evaluation questions respond to recommendations from numerous CGIAR-commissioned evaluations and reviews. Evaluation findings will feed into ToC refinement and annual program reflection.

1. **Actor engagement and assumption validation** – validates ToC assumptions against identified real-world actors.
2. **Strategic coherence across geographies** – tests feasibility of achieving consumer outcomes with limited AoW presence.
3. **AoW configuration and integration** – reviews internal structure and potential for improved synergy.
4. **Value addition of bilateral and W3-funded projects** – examines alignment and integration.
5. **Use of MELIA findings** – assesses evidence use in decisionmaking.
6. **Portfolio-level nutrition contribution** – examines system-level alignment and shared impact delivery.

The MELIA structure includes a 50% MELIA Focal Point, AoW Leads with monitoring roles, and selected scientists contributing to MELIA studies. MELIA costs for 2025 are detailed in Annex 3 of the MELIA Plan and the 2025 PORB. MELIA resources and allocations will be reviewed annually through the Reflect and Re-plan process.

The Program will use both ex-ante and ex-post impact assessment methods, including randomized controlled trials (RCTs), scenario analysis, and contribution analysis. Impact assessment focuses on causal effects and long-term impact of dietary interventions, policy

engagement, and market innovations. While impact assessment activities are currently scoped for future resource mobilization, key study themes include:

- Effectiveness of policy and institutional innovations
- Cost-effectiveness and adoption of dietary advisory tools
- RCTs assessing nutrient-rich food interventions and food environments

Impact assessment design is centrally guided by a senior impact specialist and embedded across AoWs. Collaboration will be pursued with the Standing Panel on Impact Assessment, other CGIAR Programs and Accelerators (e.g., Scaling for Impact, Policy Innovation, Gender), and Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects. Studies are most likely to be conducted in countries where there has been, or is, close engagement with policy processes and partners and knowledge generated from this Program's research. Currently, this is Bangladesh, Ethiopia, Honduras, the Philippines, Tanzania, and Viet Nam, but is subject to change as the Program evolves.

During the inception phase, the MELIA Focal Point shared the near-final draft of the revised ToC with the CGIAR Independent Evaluation and Advisory Services for feedback. To facilitate their review, the document containing the revised ToC included three tables. One table listed ISDC's comments on the ToC and how the team addressed them. The second table listed CGIAR's guiding questions for a ToC and how the team addressed them in the revised ToC and the third table was similar to Table 3.1 in this report. The ToC received an overall rating of evaluable. However, some documents were not provided at the time of the review and the Independent Evaluation and Advisory Services was not able to assess the full MELIA plan, reference to past evaluations, budget and evaluation questions. The challenge CGIAR has is to confirm the 6-year budget since this has implications to the Independent Evaluation and Advisory Services process and programs may not be in a position to fully define a plan.

*See the **Better Diets and Nutrition MELIA Plan** attachment. Results Framework is linked inside the MELIA Plan and can be downloaded from the ToC digital link mentioned in Section 3.1.*

4. Comparative advantage analysis

Better Diets and Nutrition's highly transdisciplinary work relies on integrated research teams with both technical and contextual expertise that sit within and outside of CGIAR. The domain expertise required varies by AoW. It includes expertise in diets, nutrition, and food science; behavioral science; economics; international trade and food policy; business innovation; political science and systems governance; implementation science; monitoring and evaluation (M&E); scenario modelling; agronomy and horticulture; facilitation and policy engagement; organizational development; and communications and knowledge translation. Domain expertise not available within CGIAR comes from an extensive network of partners that help generate results that contribute to planned outputs and expected outcomes. The comparative advantage exercise, combined with other stakeholder engagement in the inception phase, has not fundamentally changed the research plans, but it has given Program insights that shape the work ahead in four significant ways.

One, the team has a better understanding of what the private sector needs from CGIAR and what this Program can offer them. In the case of AoW4, conversations with potential partners at the N4G Summit and at CGIAR Science Week were particularly helpful and timely in shaping the activities the team is planning with processors and national agricultural research systems. In the case of TechnoServe this exercise has confirmed how strategic they can be for our work with the

private sector. Through their extensive knowledge of how to work with the private sector and networks with micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) in LMICs, TechnoServe has already proven to be a connector for the Program, introducing the team to new partners in Ethiopia and Kenya and facilitating the spread of information and ideas.

Two, the exercise has clarified that the majority of international NGOs do not view themselves as research organizations. They are looking for partners, like CGIAR, to provide that expertise. This is good news because this Program is looking for development partners to use their expertise and experience to implement interventions that can be studied by our team. During the inception phase, the team's ongoing conversations with international NGOs have highlighted their lack of internal capacity for research but also growing recognition that they need a trusted research partner.

Three, with the focus on increasing the intake of PNR foods as part of the food basket needed for sustainable healthy diets, CGIAR brings in-house nutrition and policy research expertise and convenes a wide range of partners with diverse expertise and skills to support the design and testing of the end-to-end approach. A key partner is WorldVeg, offering expertise in vegetable science and strong links with national and regional horticultural partners, including vegetable seed companies. With recent funding cuts to the United States Agency for International Development and the Feed the Future Innovation Labs, fewer parties remain active system-wide work on horticulture. AoW3 will deepen its strategic partnership with WorldVeg and partners to co-design and test the end-to-end approach, filling critical evidence and policy gaps.

Four, CGIAR has high-profile joint partnerships with the [Dutch](#), [French](#), and [UK governments](#), which harness their national strengths in ways that improve their scientific collaboration with CGIAR to tackle global challenges relevant to this Program. This exercise reinforced where in this Program our teams need to leverage their different sources of comparative advantage. This is, for example, the scientific expertise on environmental sustainability of diets and the food environment from Wageningen University and Research, the global platform for knowledge dissemination, science-policy interfaces, and capacity sharing from the ANH Academy supported by the UK, and regional partnership networks established by and/or coordinated by French research institutions in Southeast Asia.

*See the **Better Diets and Nutrition Comparative Advantage analysis** attachment.*

5. Prioritization

5.1 Summary of the outcomes of the prioritization exercise

As the only CGIAR Program explicitly focused on improving the consumption of sustainable healthy diets to enhance nutrition and health, Better Diets and Nutrition aligns most strongly with the IA on Nutrition. For this exercise, the team selected two of the six available indicators for this IA: the percentage of the population unable to afford a healthy diet and the percentage of women not meeting MDD, a [shared indicator](#) with SDG2 on Zero Hunger. While these do not fully capture the Program's broader impact on sustainable healthy diets, they offer a useful starting point. As also reflected in both the approved proposal and this report, the prioritization exercise confirms that all the AoWs contribute relatively equally to the IA on Nutrition. AoW5 stands out with the highest potential for impact, which is unsurprising, given its focus on multisectoral solutions with broad reach and anticipated population-level impacts on diets. The analysis also indicates that the Program's greatest regional impact is expected in South Asia (SA), followed by East and Southern Africa (ESA), and West and Central Africa (WCA).

Poor diets and malnutrition are deeply rooted in poverty and the social exclusion of population groups and individuals, which are often based on factors such as gender, age, location, ethnicity, education, and income. The prioritization exercise shows that this Program's potential to contribute to both the IA on Gender Equality, Youth, and Social Inclusion (Gender) and the IA on Poverty Reduction, Livelihoods, and Jobs (Poverty) is comparable to its contribution to the IA on Nutrition. For the IA on Poverty, however, the contributions vary more across the AoWs. The results show that AoW2 has the highest potential for impact, reflecting its strong focus on helping food system actors to grow and generate income in markets for sustainable nutritious foods.

Not every AoW contributes to the IAs on Climate Change and Mitigation (Climate) or Environmental Health and Biodiversity (Environment). The results show that the greatest potential for impact to these IAs is expected from AoW3 and AoW4, and, differently from the results for the IA on Nutrition, the results show that the potential for impact will be mainly in Southeast Asia (SEA), followed by Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) and SA.

5.2 Final decisions

The results show that the Program has the highest potential for impact on the IA on Nutrition in SA, followed by ESA and WCA. The geographical focus planned for 2025 aligns with the results. Pooled resources will be directed toward achieving HLOs related to end-to-end solutions for F&V and terrestrial animal source and aquatic foods (AoW3); consumer- and vendor-focused solutions (AoW1); interventions to reduce transaction costs and boost business growth (AoW2). These activities include evaluations of solutions, which require intensive and costly data collection. Pooled funding will also be directed to policy options and engagement that support sustainable healthy diets (AoW1, AoW3, and AoW4). In 2025, these efforts will focus on Bangladesh, India and Sri Lanka in SA; Ethiopia, Kenya, Malawi, Tanzania, and Uganda in ESA; and Benin, Ghana, and Nigeria in WCA.

The results suggest that in SEA, the Program has a modest potential for impact on the IAs on Nutrition, Poverty, and Gender. We decided that work in the Philippines and Viet Nam will continue in 2025 due to strong partner demand, alignment with national priorities, and existing contractual engagements with local partners. In both countries, local partners take on greater leadership roles in initiatives and are increasingly recognized by peers from their own and other regions as leaders in south-south learning. This Program, through AoW1, AoW3 and AoW6, will support this capacity sharing.

The results suggest the Program has a high potential for impact on the IAs on Climate and Environment in SEA. In Viet Nam, the recent merger of the Ministries of Agriculture and Environment reflects this shift. This Program has strong partnerships in Viet Nam, which strengthens opportunities to align sustainable healthy diets with climate, environment and biodiversity goals in a country widely regarded as a leader in food system transformation.

Lastly, the results suggest modest potential for impact on the IAs on Nutrition, Poverty and Gender in LAC, but high potential for impact on the IAs on Climate and Environment. In 2025, the Program will work in Honduras and Guatemala, being among the poorest countries in the region with similar strong partner demand and engagement.

In summary, informed by the comparative advantage and prioritization exercises, the decision for 2025 is to use pooled funding for work in 15 countries: Benin, Ghana, and Nigeria in WCA; Ethiopia, Kenya, Malawi, Tanzania, and Uganda in ESA; Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka in SA; the Philippines and Viet Nam in SEA; and Guatemala and Honduras in LAC. The approved proposal listed 11 countries. During the inception phase the Program collected more information about ongoing work and partnerships plus better knowledge of the Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects in the portfolio, which convinced the Program that the exclusion of Ghana, Guatemala, Malawi, and Uganda was an oversight during the proposal writing process.

Based on the results from both the prioritization and comparative advantage exercises, the Program decided to either pause or allocate budget to a minimum viable level to the following HLOs in 2025 with the expectation that, over time, budgets will be increased.

- We are pausing work on HLOs that show a lower potential for impact in 2025 relative to the others in the region as they largely build on other foundational HLOs. These cases are the HLOs on regional leadership (in AoW6) and studies on lowering UPF consumption (in AoW2). In the case of AoW3, the HLO on solutions to improve F&V intake is prioritized based on existing commitments to partners supporting the end-to-end approach. Co-design, piloting and rigorous impact assessment and evaluation require significant resources. Activities in HLOs related to terrestrial animal source and aquatic foods are modestly budgeted to allow for building end-to-end thinking and integration.
- In the case of AoW4, pooled resources will be invested in the HLO that has a higher potential for impact relative to the others, the framework for embedding nutrition in breeding pipelines. This requires modest resources and will be an important first step in 2025 before beginning work on the other HLOs on three different suites of solutions for different groups of food system actors.
- In other cases, some HLOs may show a lower potential for impact relative to the others in the region but their modest funding requirement means we can still afford to invest in them in 2025. One example of this is the HLO on policy options and engagement that support effective management of national action plans (in AoW1) in East and South Africa, South Asia, and Southeast Asia. Another example is the HLO on synthesis and dissemination (in AoW6), which is largely desk-based.
- The results from the exercise show that there is high potential for impact on the IA on Nutrition from the HLO for AoW5. AoW5 leverages sources of comparative advantage from other parties and from ongoing bilateral projects for broader nutrition and health outcomes. Nevertheless, we will postpone starting work on this HLO until 2026 when the timing to conduct meaningful synthesis will be right.

See the ***Better Diets and Nutrition Prioritization analysis*** attachment.

6. Alignment of W3 and bilaterally funded work

Seven CGIAR Centers mapped 29 separate Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects to Better Diets and Nutrition totaling US\$18.7 million in 2025 (**Section 7** and **worksheet 4 in PORB**). The Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects demonstrate strong funder interest in diets and nutrition. The projects expand the geographical scope to countries and regions where pooled funding was not prioritized in 2025. This will allow the team to apply methods and metrics and build upon tested solutions in other contexts. For example, [the living labs](#) used in the Horizon Europe partnerships on agroecology and sustainable food systems, including the Healthy Diets 4 Africa project, provide several strategies that could be used in Better Diets and Nutrition.

Twenty-three of the 29 projects (79%) are expected to contribute to two AoWs that did not have pooled funds in the prior Portfolio, Biofortified and Health-Enhancing Staples (AoW4) and Multisectoral Systems (AoW5). This is what was anticipated during the proposal writing process. It is important to state that this Program will not use pooled funds for breeding staples for higher nutrient content or health-enhancing traits. Other CGIAR Programs will allocate and manage pooled resources for that area of research. The Program expects results from 15 projects (US\$10.3 million from CIP, ICRISAT, IFPRI, IITA, and IRRI) to partly contribute to outputs and outcomes in AoW4's ToC, such as *suite of solutions for producers and processors that address constraints to sustainable healthy diets*. AoW5 will not begin activities in 2025. The Program expects that the eight projects (US\$5.1 million from IFPRI) will contribute to AoW5's ToC. These projects will help broaden our understanding of how to conduct research on the connections between food systems and health systems, social safety net programs, water-energy programs and policies before the AoW5 work begins in 2026.

A subset of projects already has mechanisms in place in 2025 to work closely with Better Diets and Nutrition. One example is the [Asia-Africa BlueTech Superhighway](#) (AABS) project on aquatic foods. The project has a credible impact pathway for improving diets but does not have an outcome as such. Our Program's involvement will add this lens in Tanzania. The AABS team will conduct studies on loss and waste; Better Diets and Nutrition will add two complementary studies: one on including nutrition as part of a cost benefit analyses of climate smart waste and loss technologies and another on nutrition-sensitive trade flows of small pelagic fish, *dagaa*. Over time, as the CGIAR System puts mechanisms in place that enable the alignment of the pooled funding and W3/bilateral projects into a single Portfolio, the Program expects there to be more examples of well-aligned projects like AABS in the Program that contribute results to the ToC and add evidence that help test assumptions.

Link to [Bilaterals & Window 3 Mapping to Programs - Power BI](#)

7. Plan of Results and Budget for 2025

The composition of the pooled and bilateral funding available for Better Diets and Nutrition shows that bilateral funding value exceeds the value of pooled resources, and that pooled resources mainly come from Window 2 allocations earmarked by donors to the Program.

● Pooled funding W1	US\$00.0M
● Pooled funding W2	US\$15.1M
● W3 and bilateral funding	US\$18.7M
● Total	US\$33.8M

The allocation of pooled funding reflects a strategic prioritization of AoWs and HLOs that directly drive the Program's results, while ensuring balanced investment across Centers to maintain delivery capacity. The budgetary decisions were guided by the results from the prioritization exercise that suggested regions and HLOs where the Program could be expected to have a higher potential impact on the IA on Nutrition.

For 2025, the Program received 68.6% (US\$15.1 million) of the initial baseline scenario budget of US\$22 million in pooled funding. This required changes in the distribution of resources to the AoWs, which differed from what was described in the approved proposal and submitted to the CGIAR System Office in the Plan of Work and Budget in November 2024. The reduced funding affected both the management budget and the research activities in the AoWs. Per instructions from the Global Science Team/Global Leadership Team, costs for cross-cutting and management activities were reduced for the second half of 2025 and distributed proportionally to the AoWs/Centers. For AoW budgets, the changes were informed by results from the comparative advantage and prioritization exercises, plus stakeholder consultation. A decision was made to pause the work of AoW5 and maintain funding for (i) AoW3's work on terrestrial animal source and aquatic foods, (ii) AoW4, and (iii) AoW6 to a minimum viable level of effort to report results in 2025 and to lay the foundation for activities in 2026.

In 2025, pooled funding will be used for focused research and fieldwork in 15 countries. The rationale for this decision is in **Section 5.2**. Pooled funding will be used to implement strategies that can strengthen collaboration between AoWs and prepare for greater integration of the Program's work across AoWs in six countries: Bangladesh Ethiopia, Honduras, the Philippines, Tanzania, and Viet Nam. These are countries where there has been, or is, close engagement with policy processes and partners and significant research has been planned but is subject to change as the Program evolves.

Table 7.1 shows the high-level breakdown of the pooled funding by AoW for 2025. Most funding goes to AoW1 and AoW3, and to a lesser extent to AoW2. The basis of this distribution is fourfold.

One, the main task of our Program is to provide evidence of transformative food system solutions that improve consumption of sustainable healthy diets. More than half of our HLOs (11) are related to providing such evidence. Funding in AoW1, AoW2, and AoW3 provides ample scope to expand, amplify, and leverage early investments in innovative solutions in these AoWs to contribute results to 8 of the 11 HLOs in 2025. Evaluating and assessing the impact of such solutions necessitates intensive data collection requiring relatively more resources. In 2025, nine of the 10 CGIAR Centers involved in Better Diets and Nutrition receive pooled funds to contribute to research within these three AoWs.

Two, country engagement is a critical part of the ToC and the Program's success, and it is facilitated by seven Country Coordinators in Bangladesh, Ethiopia, and Viet Nam (AoW1) and Benin, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, and Tanzania (AoW3). Some of these Country Coordinators have been in place since 2017. All are fully resourced by AoW1 (via the Alliance and IFPRI) and by AoW3 (via IWMI and contracts with partners).

Three, partnerships in the 15 countries are essential to complement support to research topics where CGIAR has limited comparative advantage. We have chosen to strengthen existing partnerships and to honor commitments to local partners collaborating with the CGIAR Centers, especially in AoW1 and AoW3. These are local partners like the Ethiopian Public Health Institute and the National Institute for Nutrition in Viet Nam, which collaborate with the Alliance and IFPRI in joint analysis and reporting of large household datasets on food environment and diets of

adolescents and work with the team to disseminate key messages from the results across multistakeholder platforms to influence policies and programs in the countries. The PORB table lists more partners in this category.

Four, partnerships with global collaborators and research partners are also important to the success of this Program. One example from AoW3 (via IFPRI) is WorldVeg. The Country Coordinators in Benin and Tanzania are WorldVeg staff. AoW3 relies on WorldVeg's current networks and abilities to build networks and design and deliver training and promotion activities to raise awareness of the role of vegetables in a sustainable healthy diet. Another example from AoW1 and AoW3 (both via IFPRI) is WUR. Supported by the Senior Expert Program of the Netherlands-CGIAR Strategic Partnership, WUR researchers provide expertise in qualitative research on the drivers of food choice and lived food environment experiences, facilitating capacity sharing activities, and developing practical tools for implementing systems transformation. In addition, the Program will honor commitments to support the ANH Academy and to conduct joint research with French research institutes, again extending existing collaboration via primarily AoW1 and AoW3. This aligns with high-profile initiatives CGIAR has with the [Dutch](#), [French](#), and [UK governments](#).

Table 7.1 Breakdown of pooled funding between AoWs in the baseline scenario for 2025

Areas of Work	Pooled funding (USD)
AoW1: Consumers and Food Environments	5,152,006
AoW2: Market Systems	2,075,629
AoW3: End-to-End Solutions	5,099,330
AoW4: Biofortified and Health-Enhancing Staples	226,661
AoW5: Multisectoral Systems	0
AoW6: Transformative Leadership	378,539

Cross-cutting activities for 2025

Pooled funding will be used to support collaboration with other Science Programs (**Section 8**) and for strengthening Center collaboration. For example, in AoW4 pooled funding will be used for planning and alignment of biofortification efforts of the different CGIAR Centers and identification of research questions that need to be explored to help make improved varieties a market and consumer success.

Climate change and environmental constraints are putting enormous stress on food systems, and in turn, the global changes in diets toward greater consumption of terrestrial animal source foods and UPF contribute to environmental degradation and climate change. Shifting to sustainable healthy diets that protect both human and planetary health requires major changes in consumption patterns varying by region and country and adaptation of a reference diet accommodating different countries, contexts, and population groups, while also ensuring affordability. Consumer education approaches, fiscal measures, and food environment policies are some of the solutions studied by the AoWs. In 2025, pooled funding will be used to identify key research questions where CGIAR can show comparative advantage in addressing climate and nutrition linkages in AoW1. These research questions will guide the selection of geographies and partnerships within and outside the CGIAR in 2026 for relevant research on climate and nutrition.

Pooled funding will support the integration of equity considerations across the Program's research. Since poor diets are closely linked to gender and social inequalities, all capacity sharing activities, interventions and solutions will follow a gender-sensitive approach. Solutions designed for testing and scaling consider women's roles in adoption and use, and gender impact will be included in the assessments across the AoWs. The Program views food systems transformation as an opportunity to address social inequalities, gender in particular, which contribute to and

result from unsustainable and unjust food systems. Current systems often reinforce disparities in access to and affordability of sustainable nutritious foods. Ignoring these issues risks excluding vulnerable groups, particularly women. This equity lens is built into the capacity sharing efforts of the Program, especially in AoW1, AoW3 and AoW6.

See the ***Better Diets and Nutrition 2025 PORB Replan*** attachment.

8. Cross-Portfolio linkages and geographic coordination

8.1 Cross-Portfolio linkages

Better Diets and Nutrition is committed to collaborating with other CGIAR Programs and Accelerators to maximize potential synergies, prevent duplication of efforts, strengthen relationships among local and international researchers working within the same region, and learn from other partnerships' best practices. Initially, our Program will prioritize developing collaborations with Breeding for Tomorrow, Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods, Scaling for Impact, and Multifunctional Landscapes. The Program expects that two linkages will generate results in 2025-2026 that will contribute significantly to elements of the ToC.

Breeding for Tomorrow

Breeding for Tomorrow's mission is to develop and deliver a portfolio of climate-resilient, market-preferred, *and nutritious crops, livestock, and aquatic species* that make food systems more productive, resilient, inclusive, and sustainable. In reality, breeding pipelines have prioritized yield and resilience at the expense of nutrition and consumer preference traits. However, there is renewed commitment and focus across all the breeding pipelines in the CGIAR breeding programs to mainstream biofortification and the development of health enhancing crops, and to include orphan crops as new funding becomes available, as early as July 2025. This close collaboration has also established a working group on biofortification, housed in Breeding for Tomorrow. In 2025, AoW4's priority will be the co-development of a framework for mainstreaming nutrition into breeding pipelines and processes with Breeding for Tomorrow. Activities for this framework will include stakeholder mapping exercises and development of evaluation plans to identify market segments and test consumer preference for bambara groundnut, cowpea, and taro in Nigeria and low and ultra-low GI rice in the Philippines. The framework will allow for a closer alignment and enhanced impact for the linkage between Breeding for Tomorrow and Better Diets and Nutrition in the next six years of the CGIAR Portfolio.

Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods

The mission of Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods is well-aligned to Better Diets and Nutrition. The planned collaboration with Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods will involve testing interventions that tackle desirability, availability, and affordability constraints associated with two specific food groups that make up a healthy diet, terrestrial animal source and aquatic foods. Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods works on addressing the supply-side issues and this Program addresses the consumer aspects, like studies to understand cultural norms and beliefs about animal source foods and assessments on the effects of nutrition counselling on diets. For aquatic foods, the collaboration focuses on product development of fish feed with higher concentrations of micronutrients that are bioavailable to humans when fish are consumed, thereby enhancing the healthiness of their diet. The AABS project serves as an important mechanism for the collaboration on aquatic foods. The project has a credible pathway for improving diets but does not have an outcome as such, so the involvement of both Programs will add this lens in Tanzania (**Section 6**).

8.2 Geographic coordination

The approved proposal described plans for internal coordination using Bangladesh as an example and this was positively reviewed by the ISDC. This section describes plans for cross-CGIAR coordination, using Ethiopia as an example. Ethiopia was selected because it is one of countries prioritized for strengthening AoW integration for a MELIA study planned for 2025 that will assess how fit-for-purpose is the revised ToC.

We intend to coordinate with other Programs and Accelerators using Ethiopia's NAP-FST, and what they refer to as Game Changing Solutions, as the initial entry point. We use pooled resources for full-time, in-country staff, known as Country Coordinators. The Country Coordinators use their unique skillset to build trusted partnerships and extensive networks and ensure new staff from mission-critical partners are introduced and fully engaged. In a [stocktaking workshop](#) with a small set of partners from public health and agriculture in October 2024, partners were clear that data on food environments need to include data on the supply side. By incorporating supply side issues and concerns, policy recommendations will be stronger and more convincing. In their own words, they need data on the "source of healthy diets." Our knowledge of the NAP-FST, including institutional memory on its evolution, and close engagement with the actors involved, is something we are keen to share with other Programs and Accelerators.

Other examples of collaborative research activities in Ethiopia include the development of a food safety experience scale with Food Frontiers and Security, an evaluation plan to assess lead contamination from cookware that builds on exploratory research with Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods, and two more evaluation plans related to biofortified and health-enhancing staples that will inform (i) the development of processed products that are affordable, desirable and meet the dietary needs of women and young children and (ii) approaches for building profitable value chains for those same products. These plans will be developed with Gender Equality and Inclusion, Capacity Sharing, and Scaling for Impact.

We are concerned about how to coordinate cross-CGIAR activities in Ethiopia, where multiple CGIAR Programs and Accelerators are working, to avoid fragmentation of capacity and partner fatigue. Our preferred mechanism for coordinating with other Programs and Accelerators in the same country would be a funded CGIAR Country Convenor with a clear mandate. To coordinate efficiently and reduce transaction costs, we need help. Systems or processes that facilitate the flow of information between Programs and Accelerators will help us to identify relevant opportunities and share partner requests and demands.

Activities that were done in the previous Portfolio by the CGIAR Country Convenor in Ethiopia, which were useful for this Program, include things like a mapping survey of the objectives and activities of the Programs and Accelerators in relation to the Game Changing Solutions in the Ethiopian NAP-FST and organizing and convening consultations with government leaders or other stakeholders and relevant Programs and Accelerators. The mapping that was done for UNFSS+2 in 2023 positioned CGIAR as a whole to be part of strategic ongoing policy and program processes in Ethiopia and demonstrated to other countries the convening power of CGIAR. This could be updated for UNFSS+4.

9. Risk management

Please refer to the following [link](#) with the Program/Accelerator's full risk register. This link is open to ISDC colleagues and others will be granted access on request.

#	Category	Title	Description	Current Risk Level	Target Risk Level	Actions /Controls to manage risks
1	Talent	Frequent staff turnover among mission-critical partners	High staff turnover among mission-critical partners, especially policymakers who are critical in shaping the enabling environment, in the target countries for this Program can stall progress on research, capacity sharing, and scaling. As a result, this Program and its partners may miss windows of opportunity to contribute evidence-based policy and programming innovations for sustainable healthy diets.	20	10	(1) Better Diets and Nutrition will use resources for full-time, in-country staff, also known as Country Coordinators. The Country Coordinators will use their unique skillset to build trusted partnerships and extensive networks and ensure new staff from mission-critical partners are introduced and fully engaged. In three countries in Africa (Benin, Ethiopia, and Tanzania), and four countries in Asia (Bangladesh, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, and Vietnam), Country Coordinators have been in place since at least 2022-2023. In the case of Vietnam, the role has been filled since 2017; (2) Better Diets and Nutrition will use resources for full-time, in-country staff, also known as Country Coordinators, in additional countries. Country Coordinators will use their unique skillset to build trusted partnerships and extensive networks as the work of Better Diets and Nutrition expands.
2	Partners and Partner-ships	Lack of knowledge, skills, and/or resources to manage and resolve conflicts in multisectoral coalitions	Conflicts and disagreements about priorities for improving diets and achieving nutrition outcomes persist because individual and institutional stakeholders do not understand one another and/or lack the ability to resolve them in the context of resource competition. Coalitions of food system and nutrition actors may thus be less effective in implementing innovations designed to promote sustainable healthy diets, meet social needs, and minimize negative impacts on the environment.	16	9	(1) Better Diets and Nutrition will work with partners to build capacity for conflict resolution and collaborative governance. Better Diets and Nutrition's capacity sharing efforts will design and evaluate training modules focused on conflict resolution, negotiation, and collaborative governance. These modules will be co-developed with local partners and tailored to the institutional and cultural context, enabling stakeholders to more effectively manage disagreements and co-create solutions aligned with sustainable healthy diets and broader food system and nutrition goals; (2) Better Diets and Nutrition will integrate structured stakeholder engagement components into the research program, which facilitate regular dialogue among food system and nutrition actors at different levels. This mechanism will regularly and systematically explore

#	Category	Title	Description	Current Risk Level	Target Risk Level	Actions /Controls to manage risks
						stakeholder priorities, foster mutual understanding, and identify pathways to reconcile competing interests in the context of resource constraints. At national level, this component is in place via County Coordinators (in Bangladesh, Benin, Ethiopia, the Philippines, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, and Vietnam). At regional and global level, this component will be put in place by our AoW6. For actors with strong interests in biofortified and health-enhancing staples, this component will be put in place by our AoW4.
3	Scaling impact	Influence of transnational food companies	Transnational food companies have enormous resources and job creation capacity that they use to influence consumers to choose foods that are harmful to public health and environmental sustainability. Unless the industry changes (or is forced to change) its practices, CGIAR's efforts to change dietary patterns may not measurably improve public health or protect environmental sustainability.	25	20	(1) Several countries in the Americas have successfully managed the negative consequences of transnational food companies on public health through regulation. Better Diets and Nutrition will facilitate south-south exchanges between the countries where we work and countries in the Americas to learn from their experiences; (2) Better Diets and Nutrition, with and through in-country partners, will engage with civil society, including activist groups, professional organizations, and consumer groups, to support them in their efforts to put pressure on systems to change in healthy and sustainable directions; (3) Better Diets and Nutrition will generate evidence that documents the extent ultra-processed foods are produced, marketed, and sold by transnational food companies in rural and urban areas in low- and middle-income countries. The contribution of these types of products to diets will be documented. The evidence will be shared with policymakers to help them design incentives for corporate responsibility and accountability that will be effective in their countries.
4	Ethics	Inconsistent messaging across the CGIAR System on diets and nutrition	Inconsistent and incoherent messaging about diets and nutrition by the CGIAR System Office and other Programs/Accelerators can hurt CGIAR's credibility and confuse food system actors. CGIAR research can credibly	25	12	(1) For the 2025 Nutrition for Growth Summit, Better Diets and Nutrition will collaborate with the offices of the CGIAR EMD and the Chief Scientist and CGIAR Communications & Advocacy to ensure CGIAR is present and that

#	Category	Title	Description	Current Risk Level	Target Risk Level	Actions /Controls to manage risks
			contribute to healthy diets. Suggesting that CGIAR will contribute to reductions in child stunting, however, is unrealistic and misleading. Poor messaging and overpromising can (a) hinder the willingness of food system actors in low- and middle-income countries to implement solutions (as they do not want to be held accountable for impacts that are unrealistic) and (b) negatively affect CGIAR's ability to report to funders the impact of their investments (as there will be no impact on an outcome such as stunting).			messaging on diets and nutrition is credible, consistent, and coherent; (2) For high-level events, Better Diets and Nutrition will collaborate with the offices of the CGIAR EMD and the Chief Scientist and CGIAR Communications & Advocacy to ensure CGIAR is present and that messaging on diets and nutrition is credible, consistent, and coherent; (3) Better Diets and Nutrition will launch a CGIAR working group on diets and nutrition to create awareness of the plausible impact pathways CGIAR's agriculture research for development can take to address diets and nutrition challenges and promote the use of appropriate indicators for measuring CGIAR's contribution to the Impact Area on Nutrition, Health, and Food Security.
5	Funding	Misaligned priorities and resource allocation across the CGIAR System for diets and nutrition	Misaligned priorities and resource allocation by the CGIAR System Office can undermine the efforts of the Better Diets and Nutrition program to deliver upon its objectives. Such actions can also compromise CGIAR's own ability to deliver credible results for the Impact Area on Nutrition, Health, and Food Security; CGIAR may be able to contribute to targets for ending hunger (the CGIAR's traditional area of focus) but will fall short of its ambitions to contribute to targets for reducing malnutrition. Target countries of this Program may not be able to achieve measurable positive changes in the consumption of sustainable healthy diets.	25	16	(1) The Better Diets and Nutrition Director will foster open dialogue with funders with interests in diets and nutrition to keep them engaged in this important part of CGIAR's agenda; (2) Better Diets and Nutrition will create opportunities to inform various offices within the CGIAR System (e.g., the EMD, the Chief Scientist, Communication & Advocacy, Resource Mobilization) about the program's activities and results so they can be allies in keeping this important part of CGIAR's agenda funded; (3) Better Diets and Nutrition, led by AoW4, will convene a new community of practice within CGIAR around biofortification that can be used for strategic resource mobilization.

10. Addressing feedback on select topics

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program/ Accelerator has addressed or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
Some proposals are largely rooted in linear- and technologically-focused research paradigm	Within the new CGIAR Portfolio, Better Diets and Nutrition challenges traditional ways of thinking about how to remake food systems to improve diets. Rather than focusing on solutions related to production, technology, and efficiency alone, this Program views consumers as the strategic entry point for systemic change. The Program is anchored in the HLPE food systems framework, which highlights two important things. One, the food environment has a central role in facilitating nutritious, healthy and sustainable food choices for consumers, and two, diets are an important link between food systems and their nutrition and health outcomes (HLPE 2017). This Program takes a structural view of food systems transformation that tackles the barriers to sustainable healthy diets. In other words, food systems transformation is viewed as an opportunity to improve diets and nutrition by changing the deeper, system-wide issues that prevent people from being able to eat in ways that are both good for their health and the planet. This Program embraces a systems-oriented approach to national food system transformation by embedding Country Coordinators who work closely with local stakeholders and convenors of national agendas. Rather than promoting linear solutions, the team co-creates context-specific, consumer-centered strategies—combining behavioral insights, policy reform, and technological innovation—through iterative engagement and adaptation. By grounding solutions in political economy realities and inclusive processes, the Program enhances the relevance, scalability, and sustainability of actions within the NAP-FST and other relevant frameworks.
There is a lack of information on how water systems are covered in the Portfolio.	This Program addresses water systems mainly under AoW3, with IWMI leading efforts to improve water use and reduce contamination as part of Good Agricultural Practices (GAP) bundles piloted through the production hub model. Collaborations with Applied Horticulture Research, WorldVeg, and the Tanzania Plant Health and Pesticides Authority focus on assessing irrigation and postharvest wash water quality and its impact on fresh vegetable contamination. During the previous Portfolio, holding tanks and drip irrigation were installed at GAP hubs, significantly reducing contamination compared to vegetables from normal channels. Recent surveys in Tanzanian markets found that while town water is clean, limited access and infrequent wash water changes harm produce safety. In 2025, the team plans to pilot sanitizer use in markets, focusing on GAP vegetables to provide a full supply chain solution. This integrated approach strengthens water management and food safety across the food system.
There is a lack of information on how climate mitigation is covered in the Portfolio.	This Program aims to improve the consumption of healthy diets that have a low environmental footprint. This provides a pull factor stimulating sustainable production and processing, mitigating climate change (AoW1). Reducing food loss and waste at MSME level (AoW2) and during post-harvest in F&V (AoW3) combined with adoption of climate-smart technologies along the post-production nodes of the F&V, the terrestrial animal source, and aquatic food value chains contributes to further mitigation of climate change (AoW3). AoW4 ensures nutritional or health-enhancing traits are added during the development of climate-resilient crops guided by dietary gaps (AoW4); and AoW6 will ensure the development of a clear framework to guide knowledge synthesis linking climate to diets and nutrition, while explicitly including climate considerations as part of coordination and governance efforts for diet-centered food system transformation. In the prioritization exercise, the team has been more explicit about how Better Diets and Nutrition contributes to the IA on Climate (see Section 5).
There is a lack of information on how environmental health and biodiversity is covered in the Portfolio.	In AoW3, there are activities on preserving biodiversity through breeding, seed systems development, and promoting the production and consumption of indigenous F&V. This includes addressing barriers to consumption of traditional and indigenous nutrient-rich, climate-resilient F&V, and piloting innovations to increase their use through promotion and distribution to farmers, schools, and community gardens. Efforts include improving seed systems, developing recipes and food demonstrations, and creating a prioritization framework for conservation. These activities are focused in biodiversity-rich countries such as the Philippines, Benin, Tanzania, and Sri Lanka. Improved vegetables prioritized for activities in 2025 include amaranth, okra, and African eggplant.

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program/ Accelerator has addressed or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
	Environmental health is considered through research on post-harvest and processing innovations aimed at reducing waste and improving food quality. For example, trials in the Philippines and Tanzania focus on optimizing harvest and post-harvest management of both indigenous and commercial vegetable crops, helping reduce supply chain losses and environmental burdens. This aligns with the perspective that sustainability can be achieved not only by increasing food production but by enhancing efficiency in food movement. The work supports consumer access to nutritious foods while promoting ecological sustainability and agrobiodiversity conservation. By focusing on diverse, locally adapted crops and more efficient supply chains, AoW3 contributes to sustainable healthy diets and a reduced environmental footprint across the food system.
There is a lack of information on how orphan and opportunity crops and pulses are covered in the Portfolio.	AoW3 focuses on preserving biodiversity, breeding, seed systems, and production of indigenous and traditional vegetables, which are important opportunity crops. AoW4 targets three orphan crops—bambara groundnut, taro, and cowpea—and two pulses, including beans. AoW1 works to optimize dietary patterns for sustainable healthy diets, especially for adolescents. Research shows that healthy, sustainable diets require including animal/aquatic foods, orphan and opportunity crops, pulses, and fortified foods beyond usual items. During development/revision of national FBDG, AoW1 and AoW3 explicitly promote orphan and opportunity crops and pulses to enhance dietary diversity and sustainability. This coordinated effort embeds these crops in research, policy, and dietary guidance within the Portfolio.
There is a lack of information on how youth and social inclusion (that does not relate to gender) is covered in the Portfolio.	AoW1 builds on work from the previous Portfolio focused on adolescent nutrition, dietary intake, and interaction with the food environment. Its research prioritizes low- and middle-income consumers, examining how poverty, lack of autonomy, and social exclusion drive unhealthy diets. For example, food environment surveys revealed limited youth involvement in MSME food sales in Ethiopia and Viet Nam; even a 20% annual increase in youth employment would not significantly change this. In 2025, AoW2 will investigate youth employment barriers across the value chain to determine if these barriers should be addressed or if alternative youth employment strategies are needed. In the future, AoW5 will tackle purchasing power as a major constraint to healthy diets, covering all demographics, including youth.
There is a lack of information on how capacity sharing (as it relates to internal learning and decolonization of research) is covered in the Portfolio.	Poor diets are closely linked to gender, social and power inequalities in unsustainable and unjust food systems. Our Program views food systems transformation as an opportunity to address these inequalities through strong partnerships and capacity sharing. The systematic engagement with in-country key partners (Section 2) is grounded in mutual respect for the diverse capacities, assets, and knowledge systems of all involved and focuses on strengthening local leadership in food system transformation. Partnerships in research give preference to collaboration with local researchers and research institutes in design, data collection, data analysis, reporting and dissemination of results, to contribute to shifting existing knowledge hierarchies. Building joint capacities is central to co-developing context-specific solutions, identifying locally relevant priorities, and advancing innovations that improve sustainable healthy diets. The capacity sharing activities in AoW1,3 and 6 explicitly address the role of gender and social inequalities and power dynamics in food system transformation, to support more equitable research processes, promote local leadership, and contribute to shifting power dynamics in knowledge creation. Internal learning is supported by strategies mentioned in Section 2 (annual meetings, within and outside CGIAR communities of practice and global and regional dialogues). For example, the AoW3 team's collaboration with governments and platforms like food system alliances enables shared learning alongside technical support, and capacity sharing. By embedding research and learning in global networks, AoW6 ensures that CGIAR's work contributes to broad, systemic change for improved nutrition.

Appendix 1: Addressing specific feedback

Concise summary of ISDC feedback	Details on how the Program/Accelerator has or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
Harmonize and leverage overlapping Areas of Work (for example, on MSMEs and governance systems), and Areas of Work 2-3. Actionable Recommendation #5	The revised ToC and new set of HLOs delineate the roles and contributions of AoW2 (Market Systems) and AoW3 (End-to-End Approaches) and clarified the distinct but complementary focus of each AoW. AoW2 targets market-level innovations to improve supply, affordability, and safety of nutritious foods, while AoW3 applies integrated, consumer-centered approaches to increase intake of PNR. In the separate documents linked to this report, these refinements improve coherence, reduce duplication, and support coordinated delivery of food system solutions across the value chain. Although not fully realized in the inception phase, identifying collaborative mechanisms to align efforts in shared geographies is a priority and ensure that learning flows between the teams. Several places in this report mention the active planning for coordination in shared geographies and integration of AoWs where there is overlapping interest and demand.

Concise summary of ISDC feedback	Details on how the Program/Accelerator has or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
Revisit Area of Work 1, placing consumers more centrally into the Theory of Change and explaining more clearly how food environments can be realistically changed and transformation catalyzed. Actionable Recommendation #4	This Program recognizes that transforming food environments requires coordinated, context-specific action across policy, market, and community levels. Change is catalyzed by co-designed interventions that align with national food system agendas and respond to consumer needs. These include regulatory measures (e.g., food labelling, taxes), improvements in vendor practices, and demand generation strategies like nutrition education. By embedding research in local contexts, working closely with governments, and strengthening institutional capacity, the Program supports shifts in both consumer behavior and food system incentives. This integrated, evidence-based approach creates enabling environments for sustainable healthy diets to take root and scale. In this Program's view, it is consumers, not producers or technological innovations, that are at the center of food systems transformation. Consumers are central to the revised ToC. Consumers are the agents of change, with their behaviors, constraints, and choices directly shaping the Program's impact pathways, priorities, and metrics. Consumers are not seen as passive recipients of food system changes. Instead, the revised ToC defines their agency, motivations, and the structural barriers (e.g., affordability, desirability) they face in making food choices. One of the pathways the Program will use to achieve dietary change is consumer-oriented policy strategies, which includes tools like FBDG, taxes, food labeling, and vendor regulations to shift food environments and support healthier choices. Affordability of a healthy diet is one of the main drivers of consumer food choices, influenced by food prices, household income, and consumer motivations. This Program addresses this challenge through demand-side driven strategies not only in AoW1 but across several AoWs, combined with supply-side strategies in collaboration with CGIAR's production-oriented Programs. Examples of such strategies are price reductions (vouchers, subsidies), improved information (labelling) (AoW1, AoW3), reducing transaction costs and increasing access to finance to grow markets and reduce prices for nutritious foods (AoW2), reducing post-harvest losses (AoW2, AoW3); strategies to reduce production costs of biofortified and health-enhancing crops together with production-oriented Science Programs (AoW4); and link social protection measures and school meals to include nutritious foods to lower costs of healthy diets for families (AoW5). AoW6 will synthesize evidence from all AoWs to identify the most effective solutions in improving affordability, highlighting trade-offs and feedback loops.
Revisit Area of Work 4, with indication of demand, potential cost-effectiveness and co-creation aspects of the new biofortified varieties proposed. Actionable Recommendation #6	The Program's work on biofortified and health-enhancing staples responds to strong stakeholder demand, reinforced during CGIAR Science Week and the N4G Summit, where partners emphasized the need for consumer-oriented research on these crops. Recognizing CGIAR's comparative advantage in breeding and policy research, the Program focuses product development, market research, and consumer testing, results which will help scale biofortified varieties like orange-fleshed sweet potato and low-GI rice. Co-creation is central: research is conducted with national agricultural research systems, processors, and local communities to ensure cultural relevance and adoption. By promoting minimally processed, nutrient-dense staples that meet dietary needs and market preferences, the Program aims to generate scalable, cost-effective solutions to improve diet quality and reduce micronutrient deficiencies in LMICs.

Concise summary of ISDC feedback	Details on how the Program/Accelerator has or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
Bolster climate change and other sustainability aspects throughout, including at Areas of Work workplans level. Actionable Recommendation #2	Space limitations in this report template limit the level of detail that can be provided. Internal workplans, more detailed than the PORB, can be provided upon request. This Program aims to improve the consumption of healthy diets that have a low environmental footprint. This provides a pull factor stimulating sustainable production and processing, mitigating climate change (AoW1). Reducing food loss and waste at MSME level (AoW2) and during post-harvest in F&V (AoW3) combined with adoption of climate-smart technologies along the post-production nodes of the F&V, the terrestrial animal source, and aquatic food value chains contributes to further mitigation of climate change (AoW3). AoW4 ensures nutritional or health-enhancing traits are added during the development of climate-resilient crops guided by dietary gaps (AoW4); and AoW6 will ensure the development of a clear framework to guide knowledge synthesis linking climate to diets and nutrition, while explicitly including climate considerations as part of coordination and governance efforts for diet-centered food system transformation. In the prioritization exercise, the team has been more explicit about how Better Diets and Nutrition contributes to the IA on Climate (see Section 5). In AoW3, there are activities on preserving biodiversity through breeding, seed systems development, and promoting the production and consumption of indigenous F&V. This includes addressing barriers to consumption of traditional and indigenous nutrient-rich, climate-resilient F&V, and piloting innovations to increase their use through promotion and distribution to farmers, schools, and community gardens. Efforts include improving seed systems, developing recipes and food demonstrations, and creating a prioritization framework for conservation. These activities are focused in biodiversity-rich countries such as the Philippines, Benin, Tanzania, and Sri Lanka. Improved vegetables prioritized for activities in 2025 include amaranth, okra, and African eggplant. Environmental health is considered through research on post-harvest and processing innovations aimed at reducing waste and improving food quality. For example, trials in the Philippines and Tanzania focus on optimizing harvest and post-harvest management of both indigenous and commercial vegetable crops, helping reduce supply chain losses and environmental burdens. This aligns with the perspective that sustainability can be achieved not only by increasing food production but by enhancing efficiency in food movement. The work supports consumer access to nutritious foods while promoting ecological sustainability and agrobiodiversity conservation. By focusing on diverse, locally adapted crops and more efficient supply chains, AoW3 contributes to sustainable healthy diets and a reduced environmental footprint across the food system.

Concise summary of ISDC feedback	Details on how the Program/Accelerator has or will address this feedback (in the Inception Phase or beyond)
Bolster other social inclusion aspects throughout, including at Areas of Work workplan level. Actionable Recommendation #3	Space limitations in this report template limit the level of detail that can be provided. Internal workplans, more detailed than the PORB, can be provided upon request. AoW1 builds on work from the previous Portfolio focused on adolescent nutrition, dietary intake, and interaction with the food environment. Its research prioritizes low- and middle-income consumers, examining how poverty, lack of autonomy, and social exclusion drive unhealthy diets. For example, food environment surveys revealed limited youth involvement in MSME food sales in Ethiopia and Viet Nam; even a 20% annual increase in youth employment would not significantly change this. In 2025, AoW2 will investigate youth employment barriers across the value chain to determine if these barriers should be addressed or if alternative youth employment strategies are needed. In the future, AoW5 will tackle purchasing power as a major constraint to healthy diets, covering all demographics, including youth.
Consider including some material early on that captures the work of the 2022-24 initiatives and how that leads on to the proposed work. Actionable Recommendation #7	This has been addressed in the ~250 words allowed in Section 1.2. We will also describe this on our microsite when we have permission and guidance from the CGIAR Communications & Advocacy team.
Include more details on the specific research being proposed and how it will be conducted...The research questions outline broad, overarching goals and lack specificity. This may stem from the instructions provided to the writing teams. Actional Recommendation #9	This has been addressed in the 2 pages allowed in Section 1.3.
Consider reflecting further on areas where CGIAR comparative advantage is not evident, and on how this will inform partnerships. Actionable Recommendation #8	This has been addressed in Section 4 and the accompanying table.
Strengthen the demand-led prioritization section, making clear the extent of external consultation and the rationale for country prioritization. Actionable Recommendation #1	This has been addressed in Section 5 and the accompanying table. Informed by the comparative advantage and prioritization exercises, the decision for 2025 is to use pooled funding for work in 15 countries: Benin, Ghana, and Nigeria in WCA; Ethiopia, Kenya, Malawi, Tanzania, and Uganda in ESA; Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka in SA; the Philippines and Viet Nam in SEA; and Guatemala and Honduras in LAC. The approved proposal listed 11 countries. During the inception phase the Program collected more information about ongoing work and partnerships plus better knowledge of the Window 3 and bilaterally funded projects in the portfolio, which convinced the Program that the exclusion of Ghana, Guatemala, Malawi, and Uganda was an oversight during the proposal writing process.